SEVENTEEN

The Biography in the Shadow

The life history may be thought of as a process that blends together the consciousness of the investigator and the subject, perhaps to the point where it is not possible to disentangle them. . . . If the investigator relies in a primary way on personal resources in understanding the subject of the life history as another person, then in some sense the life history may represent a personal portrait of the investigator as well. The portrait would take the form of a shadow biography, a negative image.

—Gelya Frank, "Finding the Common Denominator: A Phenomenological Critique of Life History Method"

Okay, so technically speaking, I'm not a gringa. I'm Cubana, born in Cuba, raised in a series of noisy apartments in the sad borough of Queens, New York, that smelled of my mother's sofrito. I spoke Spanish at home, learned English in school, where I was in the "dumb class" for a while until I could speak, the first in the family and El Grupo to become a profesora. I was crossing borders without knowing it long before I met Esperanza—but through knowing her, I've reflected on how I've had to cross a lot of borders to get to a position where I could cross the Mexican border to bring back her story to put into a book. We cross borders, but we don't erase them; we take our borders with us.

I have supposedly been privileged from the beginning, a Cubanita, another "model minority," a success story, the welcome mat of the American government spread at my feet, in grateful exile from the shackles of communism in the land of freedom, always grateful, never asking for too much, thank you, thank you very much, *gracias por todo*, and sorry for any trouble. "What sa matta?"—as Abuelo, my grandfather, my father's father used to say, just about the only words I

ever heard him speak in English. As a young girl I was told constantly that it was impolite, even immoral, to criticize the United States. "What sa matta? *¿De qué te quejas? ¿Dime, qué te falta?*" Always those refrains: What don't you have? You think you could have worn that dress, those shoes, if we had stayed in Cuba? You think you would have been able to read all those books? You think you'd be so free to talk the way you do? You should say thank you to this country.

I'm a Cubana, but in Mexico I'm a gringa because I go to Mexico with gringa privileges, gringa money, gringa credentials, not to mention a gringo husband and a gringo car. After all, I cross the border with an American passport. In her poem, "Legal Alien," the Chicana poet Pat Mora describes the shift of identity that takes place depending on what side of the border you are standing on:

an American to Mexicans
a Mexican to Americans
a handy token
sliding back and forth
between the fringes of both worlds
by smiling
by masking the discomfort
of being pre-judged
Bi-laterally.[1]

The kindest compliment about my identity I ever received in Mexquitic came from the local thief and juvenile delinquent as we stood around in Don Juan's general store having a beer with a few men just returned from a stint working in the States. This young man, just out of jail again, took a sip of his beer and said to me, "People like you here. We think of you as a *norte mexicana*." He was trying to tell me that while I'm not quite Mexican, I'm not quite American either, because I speak Spanish so well and interact easily with Mexicans; I'm something in between, a cross between a North American and a Mexican, a "North Mexican."

I like this mestiza identity. I can indulge in the thought that I am something other than a gringa, I who have sought, like the Puerto Rican writer Rosario Morales, always to be "the reasonable one," the easy-to-get-along-with-Latina, the Latina who makes no waves and

claims no difference for herself, the Latina who is "white like you, english-speaking like you, right-thinking like you, middle-class-living like you, no matter what I say."[2] But being "the reasonable one" in Mexico meant that I also had to grin and bear it when they took me for a gringa. How could I explain that I was not a gringa, not totally a gringa, anyway? Trying to figure out where I stood on the border between the United States and Mexico, I felt as though the fault lines of the divided America were quaking within me. Which America was my America? To which of the Americas did I owe allegiance? How well I remember the pain in a compadre's voice when I refused his request that I claim him as next of kin to help him get across the border. "But didn't you tell me that you and your family aren't from there, that you also had to struggle to get in?" he asked, deeply hurt.

In our little Cuban circle of El Grupo, we were well aware of our privilege relative to other Spanish-speaking emigrants, especially Puerto Ricans and Mexicans, who did not get as warm a welcome as we had from the American government. We had the privilege of our color, our aspiration to be middle class, our symbolic capital as wormy resisters of Fidel Castro's impudent challenge to the United States. The yanquis had been nice to us, *bien chéveres*, so why should we be difficult? No one seemed to notice that we had ended up with the yanquis because of the long history of United States intervention in Cuba. We were content to be able to go to La Rumba Restaurant every weekend for *frijoles negros* and *bistec de palomilla*, and to Miami Beach for two weeks vacation in July, during the off-season, the only time we could afford to go, when the yanquis thought it was crazy to be there, burning enough layers of skin to last us until the following year.

So I have been privileged, to be sure, from the beginning. And among those privileges I, too, must include, as does Sandra Cisneros, that "I grew up with a mother who prepared me for a life in literature instead of a life in the kitchen."[3] It is a strange privilege this, of having a mother who even today comes to put order in my house, clearing out my closets and filling up my freezer with *frijoles negros*, chicken cutlets, blintzes, and *tamales*, a mother who every year before I go to Mexico buys costume jewelry, sneakers, flannel nightgowns, *vestiditos*, and *pantaloncitos* for me to take to all my comadres and godchildren, a mother who does all this so that I can keep working, writing,

doing what I need to do to survive. So the native woman in my life, the woman who was first "other" to me, has in some sense always been my mother, the woman who has done my woman's work so I could read and write books. My mother prepared me for a life reading books instead of a life in the kitchen, and yet, without my knowing it, that life beyond the kitchen led me back to a kitchen, the kitchen in Mexico, the kitchen in this book.

It is not just my mother who has done my "woman's work" so I could read and write books. My gringo husband has also spared me from a life in the kitchen. He cooks, cleans, washes the clothes, does the grocery shopping, picks up my mail at the office; he spares me from the everydayness of things, so I can shut myself up at home and do my work. He even puts in all the missing accent marks on my Spanish words. He's a saint of a gringuito, really. From the beginning I let him know that I'm mean and hard to live with, and never grateful enough. I have accused him of taking away my culture when he won't let the *plátanos fritos* burn in the oil till they're totally oozing and charred. My mother sometimes tells me to cool it, that *los hombres se cansan*, you know. Don't think he'll put up with it forever, she warns me. And in Mexquitic, the women also told me, "*Es de los buenos, así que cuídelo.*" Finding a good man, a man who doesn't need a mother, doesn't beat you, doesn't put you down, is a privilege, it seems. So, yes, my gringo husband is another one of my "privileges."

Yet how often haven't I asked myself, What is a Cubanita like you doing with all these ambitions of reading and writing books? Having explored here the many ironies of turning Esperanza's historias into a book, I realize that what I haven't said yet is just how wrenching has been my own relationship to books and the world of book-learning. Unless I find the words to tell the story of how I came to be able to write the story of another, less-privileged woman's life, I feel that this book will not be complete. I need to tell the story of how I came to the privilege of my pen. That is the biography in the shadow.

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Ruth's spoken and written Spanish is excellent, almost flawless, and is not limited to the quotidian "kitchen Spanish" of so many native speakers residing in the U.S. Ruth's Spanish is

a tool worthy of her sophisticated and knowledgeable approach to literature.

—Undergraduate teacher's narrative evaluation, spring 1975

I found Ruth's sense of poetic drama particularly compelling. She is at her best when her imagination can get full rein. It's a pity when the facts sometimes get in the way! But I would hate for her to be any more pedestrian. Occasional weirdness is well worth having when there are moments of such insight and even poetry.

—Undergraduate teacher's narrative evaluation, spring 1975

I do not think that Philosophy is an activity for which Ruth is by mental nature exactly suited (that is certainly not meant as a derrogatory [sic] statement, god knows, she may be blessed in this regard); she is an associator rather than an arguer, her imagination seems to be more plastic than abstract. She did very well with very difficult material in a situation for which she was not by training prepared or by natural affinity disposed.

—Undergraduate teacher's narrative evaluation, spring 1976

As a young girl, I ate books, especially novels, poetry, and philosophy books. The more books I consumed, the more shame I felt about who I was and where I had come from. I was already plotting to leave Queens, and books were to be my passport to the other worlds I wanted to enter, the worlds of thinking, writing, soft voices, quiet study. How I used to irritate the hell out of my father, who liked to sing cha-cha songs out loud at the top of his voice, with my need for long silences; he'd accuse me of having turned the house into a funeral parlor.

And yet my father wanted me to go to Queens College, so I would continue to live at home until I got married, as had been the custom for young girls in Cuba. But I knew we would all have gone crazy if I had

stayed home. My brother was a budding musician, and he liked loud rock at the time, not the Mozart that I had tried, in vain, to introduce into the family. The only place where I could read in relative peace was at the bottom of the stairs leading up to our apartment. My mother knew I dreamed of attending an elite private university away from home, and she snuck money out of the checkbook for me to pay the application fees. When the acceptances came in, my father was furious at the little betrayal concocted by my mother and me, but he finally relented; and in the fall of 1974 I left home for one of the little ivy colleges, hoping to become a writer. Once there, I decided to major in the College of Letters, an expanded "Great Books of the Western World Program," under the assumption that if I could read the "great books" I would gain the tools to think great thoughts and write great books.

I felt insecure, wondering whether I had been admitted solely as a "Hispanic," but I intended to prove that I was not a minority student who required special privileges or accommodations. I turned down a room in the Latino House. I knew that I could pass. My Spanish, as my Anglo-American Spanish professor put it in his narrative evaluation, was not "kitchen Spanish" (thankfully!) but some properly literary Spanish that had been wiped clean of the dirt from its roots. And I spoke English, unlike my parents, without a "Latin" accent; in fact, I spoke with an affected British accent that I had taught myself after trying it out first in a high school play (that affectation soon wore off, and I started speaking with what my brother called a "college accent"). I passed so well that I used to irritate a boyfriend when I spoke of how foreign I sometimes felt in the United States. "Come on, you didn't just get off the boat," he'd say.

Maybe I hadn't just gotten off the boat, but the world of the academy, where people seemed invested not in loving books but in being able to talk about them impressively, was a world for which my immigrant milieu had not prepared me. No one in our Grupo of sales clerks, accountants, and engineers turned owners of shoestores and envelope factories could understand what this College of Letters, this *colegio de letras*, was about, and they all thought I was wasting my time. I was continually reminded by my mother that my studies, even with the financial aid I received, were a *sacrificio*, and that I had to be grateful for the education I was getting. My mother had begun to work outside the house at a clerical job, and I knew very well that the devel-

opment of my mind was being financed by the labor of her body. My father, meanwhile, was still fuming that I had left home. The guilty daughter, I worked summers as a typist in New York City to earn my keep, and after my first semester at college I arranged to graduate a year early by doing independent coursework. I didn't dare tell my parents I was miserable at college; I didn't dare tell myself, either.

And then "it" happened, or rather two events took place that are intimately associated in my memory. In the new year of 1976, I came back from a semester abroad in Madrid, where I had gone to "perfect" my Cuban Spanish. I was home for a few days before returning to college and was trying desperately to read Plato, a stack of Greek tragedies, and Thucydides, which I had promised my teachers I would read and study on my own as part of the plan to allow me to graduate a year early. I remember I took Plato with me to the kitchen, the narrow kitchen in the Forest Hills apartment with the pale yellow formica counter and the matching wallpaper of massive sun-drenched marigolds that matched the sheets on my parents' bed, those sheets which years later I would take with me to Mexquitic. I was drinking orange juice and holding down a page of Plato with my mother's browning copy of *Cocina Criolla*, the cookbook she had brought with her from Cuba, when my father appeared in the kitchen. I had been away for six months, but somehow I had already managed to make my father angry.

"*Ni buenos días, ni* Hi Papi, *ni nada.*"

"Sorry, I was reading," I mumbled.

He sat down on the other bar stool by the counter and looked straight at me. My mother must not have been home. Fear began to gnaw at my throat when I noticed he had some airmail letters in his hand. Pulling out one of the letters from the pile, he began to read aloud in the tone of a prosecutor, "I miss you so much. Mami y Papi, *no saben cuanto les quiero. Mucho cariño, su hija, Ruty.*" I realized with dread that he was reading aloud from one of my letters, a letter I had written home from Spain.

He put the letter back in the envelope, folding it exactly where it was already creased. Then he tore it up, slowly, methodically. I was so stunned I couldn't say a word. He took up the next letter and tore it, and the next and the next. How many letters were there? I can only remember a pile of little pieces of paper, colorful as confetti, with my

writing on them, embers lying on the yellow formica counter. He tore the letters with the cool precision he used to shave his face or wipe his mouth after dinner.

"*¡Son mentiras!* Lies!" And then in a singsong imitation, "I miss you so much, Mami y Papi."

I cannot find my tongue.

"*¡Mentiras!* You love your mother and your father, then you show it! *¿Un beso para tú padre? ¡Nada!* You can't kiss your father hello? You can't kiss your mother hello? *Tanto qué ella hace por ti. Nada* . . . Those letters, *sabes lo qué son? ¡Caca! ¡Mierda!* Shit! *¡Pa la basura, todo!*"

He edged the neat little pile of torn up letters into his palm and squashed them. With his other hand, he opened the cabinet door under the sink. He opened his palm and the mush of words landed in the garbage heap piled high with chicken bones and burnt yellow rice from the previous night's dinner. I simply sat there, and when he left I turned back to Plato.

A few days later I was back at college. Although at the end of the semester I would be taking my comprehensive examinations in the College of Letters, I decided not to devote my time to studying. Instead, I chose to direct a García Lorca passion play, *The House of Bernarda Alba*, about a mother's struggle to maintain control over her daughters and their virginity, a play that required an all-female cast. No grades were given for coursework done in the College of Letters, just narrative statements, so the "comps" counted a great deal, and both students and professors took them very seriously. I remember everybody around me studying like mad, and I, lost inside the house of Bernarda Alba.

Although the García Lorca play was a success, my comps were disastrous. No, I didn't fail them; that, at least, would have been dramatic. Instead, I received a "creditable," an ugly, borderline grade that only I and the worst goofball in the class received in a group of honors, high honors, and highest honors. I was crying by my mailbox in the College of Letters when the teacher I most venerated then, an immeasurably articulate professor of philosophy, the one who wrote in her narrative evaluation that I was not mentally suited to pursue Philosophy with a capital P, saw me and led me into a colleague's office. After a few brief

words of consolation, she proceeded to ignore me and tell her colleague how useful it was to have an objective scale by which to rate the students in the class.

In the months that followed, I was treated as a reject of the intellectual assembly line. That, not the grade, was what really hurt. I was left out of a Heidegger tutorial with the philosopher I had venerated. I could find no one to supervise my senior thesis. And then a professor who had taken pity on me began to put his arms around me whenever I'd go to his office, and he'd ask if I wouldn't go to a motel with him; I hadn't yet learned to say the words "sexual harassment." All I knew was that the keepers of the "great books" no longer thought me worthy. Despite my grand hopes, where I really belonged was either in the College of Remedial Reading or in a motel bed being nice to my male professors. So now I knew the truth: I was in college because I was "Hispanic." I had never left the "dumb class."

Out of a sense of shame, I had left behind all the things associated with home in order to cross the border into the world of Letters, only to discover that this world didn't want me and that there was no returning home, either. Like the trail of bread left by Hansel and Gretel, the path home was strewn with the pieces of my letters my father had torn up, and I no longer knew my way back.

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Over the years these two events, my father's tearing up of my letters home, and my being cast into the margins of the great Letters, have come to occupy the larger space in my memory of primal scenes. They are primal scenes of my tongue gone dry, scenes of terror, when both my heart and my mind were broken in pieces. I reveal them for the first time here because they offer a parallel from my life to the kind of annihilating violence Esperanza describes in her account, violence that ravaged the emerging self of the young woman. The violence directed at me was psychic, not inscribed on my body, as it was for Esperanza, and, given my class position, I was properly fed in the midst of my sufferings. But the pain was nonetheless profound; its thick ink still clogs my pen.

Between my father's tearing up of my letters for not being true and the doubts of my teachers about whether I was fit to join the great tradition of Letters, I received the message that I was both an emotional

and an intellectual failure. Only now, fifteen years later, can I begin to imagine other readings of those events. I wonder now whether my father's act of violence toward me, what I perceived as his rape of my letters, was his way of challenging the frighteningly cold, distant American person I seemed to be turning into, the daughter who had no hugs or kisses for her mother and father, the daughter who was moving farther and farther away from home. In that light my refusal to study for the comps may, in turn, have been my way of returning his act of violence by undercutting the family sacrifice to educate me. By treating the great books, my passport into those other worlds I so desperately wanted to enter, as unimportant to me, I expressed my defiance. No longer would I be the good schoolgirl, through whom he and my mother could vicariously claim that the yanquis had been good to us. But neither would I be able to rise above the bottom of the stairs in the Queens apartment, for I had clipped my own wings.

My calling in life, I had begun to think, was to be a typist, forever typing other people's words because I did not deserve to inscribe any of my own. I was then, and am still now, an ace typist, having learned to type at the age of nine. It was my father who had the idea that I should learn to type. He brought home a step-by-step typing manual with an orange cover and told me that I was to do a lesson a day and learn to type without looking at the keys. A car accident that he had been unable to avert late one night on the Belt Parkway had left me immobile for a year with a broken femur. The typing was meant to teach me a useful feminine working-class skill while I recovered. At the age of nine, I could be thrilled at my typing skills; but at the age of nineteen those same skills felt like a life sentence, an ironic comment on my destiny. And much later, as I approached my thirty-fifth birthday while working to turn my comadre's words into paper, I would again be consumed with worry about whether the fearful prophecy of my being a typist, forever transcribing someone else's words, had in some quite fiendish way actually come true.

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Let me show you my wounds: my stumbling mind, my "excuse me" tongue . . .

—Lorna Dee Cervantes, "Poem for the Young White Man Who Asked Me How I, an Intelligent, Well-Read

***Person, Could Believe in the War between Races," from* Emplumada**

Not long after those events, as I licked my wounds, I started, ever so hesitantly, to think that, maybe, just maybe, there was a problem with the view that what was most worth knowing about culture and thought could be contained in a single shelf of books. I started to wonder about the exclusions in that shelf, and the sense of entitlement of its keepers.[4] At the same time, not claiming too much consciousness in retrospect, I also know that I felt horribly, hopelessly stupid. Some part of me did believe that the comps had, indeed, been an objective measure of my place in the scheme of things, as the venerated teacher had thought, too. Like the teenage girls about whom Carol Gilligan has recently written, I experienced an acute sense of not knowing what I knew.[5]

As those not-knowing-what-I-knew thoughts began to take form in my head during my final year in college, I decided to take my first course in anthropology. It was a course in theories of society and culture taught by a defrocked priest turned philosopher turned anthropologist. I was in the wilderness then, so the insight that all products of culture, great books included, were social constructions, not timeless monuments that spoke in a universal language, fell upon me like manna. Maybe, just maybe, it was not a lack of "natural affinity" or a deficient "mental nature" that kept me from doing better in Philosophy with a capital P, but a sense of alienation at its cultural and linguistic otherness.[6] In anthropology I felt I had found an intellectual home. Here, the little shelf of great books was seen for what it was: just one little shelf.

My first teacher of anthropology pushed me to go to graduate school. With his unrelenting insistence, I applied to two schools and got into one of them. I decided that this time I was going to discipline myself better. I would not resist being taught. I would take my exams seriously. If I could get through graduate school I would prove to myself I was not so stupid after all—maybe, blessed as I was in my philosophy teacher's estimation, I'd never be mentally suited for Philosophy, the Queen of all the disciplines, but I would earn a place in Her court.

In graduate school, I forced myself to learn to write cold-blooded logical essays with a beginning, middle, and end; and I forced myself to

keep my flights of imagination in check, to learn to muzzle them to facts. I worked very hard and the work paid off; I became a star pupil. When it came time to write my dissertation about the way of life and history of a small peasant village in northern Spain, I wrote an elegant exposition about the relationship between family inheritance and communal land tenure. There was no link between this topic and my life; it was a pure intellectual exercise.[7] My teachers liked my dissertation enough to recommend it for immediate publication, so that at a fairly young age and at an early point in my career, I already had a book to show for myself.

But when the dissertation was done, I felt as did Michelle Cliff: "My dissertation . . . was responsible for giving me an intellectual belief in myself that I had not had before, while at the same time distancing me from who I am, almost rendering me speechless about who I am. At least I believed in the young woman who wrote the dissertation—still, I wondered who she was and where she had come from."[8]

Graduate school had given me back the confidence in my intellect that had been knocked out of me in college. But I realized that this confidence had been won at a price: in my years of graduate school and dissertation writing, I had been forced to put aside all the burning questions of my own identity and the painful memory of the torn personal and literary letters that had propelled me into anthropology in the first place. I had come to feel that my personal identity was neither relevant nor important. There was nothing special about me. Society, culture, history: didn't those collective forms have everything to do with what we are? My life I had put on hold; I'd eventually get to reply to it, I thought, when I found some time. As an anthropologist, I had an obligation to give voice to others. To give myself voice was narcissistic, indulgent; even now, I still feel the weight of this view.[9]

The dissertation writing, and the writing I initially did about colonial Mexican women's confessions to the Inquisition, established me, in ways I do not fully understand, as a member of the professional managerial class. I believed in the young woman who, not quite thirty yet in 1986, saw her first book published by a prestigious university press, gave birth to her first baby, and took her first almost-real-job as a postdoctoral fellow at the University of Michigan. I was still speechless about who I was and I still had an "excuse me" tongue, but my credentials told me that at least I had an intellect.

As I began to work seriously on Esperanza's life story while making myself believe I was a professor at Michigan, I wanted this project to start pointing me home after the years of academic exile. I had no clear idea at first of how the life history of a Mexican woman street peddler was going to say anything about the Cubanita who had gone away to college against her father's wishes planning to become a fiction writer but turning into an anthropologist instead. I was reading and teaching all the personal narratives I could get my hands on, and especially those written by American women with knotted borderland identities, but I had begun to think that whatever personal statement I was going to make would have to be done in a different context. I couldn't see a way to mix Esperanza's narrative and my narrative in the same pot.

And then some unexpected things happened. It was 1988. I had one year left of my three-year position at Michigan, when I was offered a job at an idyllic university in California. For me, that campus on the hill with the ocean on the horizon became the imaginary Cuba I had longed to find; what could be better, a Cuban friend joked, than a Cuba without Cubans? Just as I was trying to decide whether I ought to accept the job in my imaginary Cuba, I was asked whether I might be interested in a job at Michigan. There was no regular job available at the moment, I was told, but there were funds available for positions designated "target of opportunity," to be filled by minority people. Would I consent to being considered for a position as a Latina? I said I would. A colleague in my department confessed that as far as she was concerned I was just like her, that she didn't see me as a Latina, but that the minority route was a way to get me in.

A few weeks later the request for a minority position for me was turned down by the administration. Apparently I was not an authentic enough Latina because my four grandparents had been European Jewish immigrants to Cuba. An extensive genealogy was put together, not unlike the *limpieza de sangre* writs of the Inquisition that sought to determine "purity of blood," and it was decided that "my race" wasn't pure Cuban because I had European blood in my veins.[10] Anyway, quite apart from that, it wasn't Cubans the administration needed to fill the target of opportunity slots; they already had at least two Cubans on the faculty. The best the administration could do was offer me a three-year visiting position, which might eventually be turned into a regular position. I was told that a visiting position at a major university was

worth a lot more than a tenure-track position at the smaller college I wanted to go to in California. Unconvinced, I turned Michigan down to go to my imaginary Cuba.

That took place in May. And then in July, while I was in Mexico working with my comadre on this book, I was awarded a MacArthur fellowship, a fellowship with tremendous mystique in the academic world. It is impossible to apply for a "Big Mac." The award comes from heaven like the Archangel Gabriel, and it's yours for five years without any strings attached. Immediately a telegram arrived for me in Mexico: overnight, it seemed, a real position had become available for me at Michigan, not just a visiting position. It was difficult not to be cynical; being told first that I was not a legitimate Latina, then being told that I ought to be happy to stay on at the university with a temporary job, and suddenly, because I had won an important prize, being offered a tenure-track position. No, I thought to myself, let me just go to my imaginary Cuba. But in my new state of grace, Michigan would not let me get away so easily. I was asked what it would take to get me to stay. "Tenure," I replied, feeling as if I'd asked for the moon. And, to my surprise, a few months later I was offered tenure. Tenure for me, the Cubanita that had once been turned back at the border?

Then I was really stuck. Should I stay at Michigan with the job written in stone and the financial security, or take a risk and go to my imaginary Cuba, where I now had the lesser offer of a position with no definite promise of tenure? Staying seemed safe and easy and smart; leaving seemed difficult and brave and romantic. How I agonized over this decision.

I have a huge need for financial security; the immigrant in me has a fear of ending up homeless and in the gutter. Over the years, I had also taken on the role of breadwinner within the little threesome of our nuclear family exiled in the Midwest. David had put his career on hold in order to care for Gabriel and had not yet finished his dissertation. In between teaching, writing, and conferences, I had given Gabriel my breast full of *leche nerviosa*, as my father called it, the "nervous milk" of work and worry. And now I had to decide not only what was best for me but for the three of us.

I made the mistake of sharing some of my uncertainty with my parents. For them the answer was obvious: stay at Michigan. "Oh, wow, you have a daughter at Michigan? *No, Ruty, la gente se impresiona*

mucho cuando uno dice Michigan." I'd be silly to give up a job at such an important university. Angered, I answered back, "You just use me to gain prestige!" That was a cheap shot, I knew, and I was ready for the scolding. "That's not nice, Ruty," my father said. "We're proud of you, *pero si quieres que no hablemos de ti, no vamos a decir nada*!" And again I was the evil daughter, who deserved to have her letters torn up.

Reluctantly, I told the people at California that I needed tenure if I was to go there. Never in my wildest fantasies had I imagined I would be in a position to make such demands. I know that to outsiders it seemed as though I was ratcheting up the offers with supreme chutzpah, but I felt miserable about the whole process. Meanwhile, back at Michigan, people were becoming upset because I had not immediately grabbed the offer of tenure. What else did I want, after all? To stall for time I began negotiating: for time off from teaching, for salary, for a late deadline for my decision. It all felt out of character to me. The only thing that was in character was my indecisiveness.

While I was in Miami Beach in late February of 1989 visiting my grandmother, I got a call from Michigan. Somehow they had managed to track me down. They were very sorry but they could not give me any more time to decide about the job offer; by the following week, I had to take it or leave it. I politely listened to this ultimatum and didn't get angry, didn't protest. I was "nice." I said "please excuse me" and "thank you," just as I was taught by my parents. Then I called California. So, were they going to give me tenure? I needed to know right away. Well, they'd see what they could do, but they weren't sure they could work anything out that quickly.

On the day I had to make my decision, I got a call from the "sheriff" of my imaginary Cuba. Clearly, she was annoyed at all the trouble I was causing. "You've jumped over too many hoops," she said to me in her staccato voice, "and now you want me to let you jump over another hoop. I don't know why you're so worried about tenure. If you've gotten all those awards, then you shouldn't have to worry—if you deserved them, that is . . ." The Cubanita was being put in her place, at last. I wanted to be angry, but I felt I deserved that scolding, too. I was asking for too much. I had to be grateful for what I had been given; don't ask for too much, and always be grateful, say thank you, thank you very much, *gracias por todo*.

I had just hung up with the sheriff when the phone rang again. It was my mother, wanting to know what I had decided. She was calling from her basement office at New York University, where she works as a typist. "*¿Qué vas a hacer, Ruty?*" she asked, tender, concerned, anxious. She had already told me quite clearly that she would be sorry if I moved so far away to California. But I didn't want to hear about her desires; I wanted to be American, free to go wherever I pleased. I could feel the rage I had been withholding gathering force. Any minute I would yell, scream, be ugly. "I don't want to talk to you! Leave me alone!" And I hung up. Several minutes later I got my composure back and called the chair of anthropology at Michigan. "I'll be happy to take the job," I said. "Sorry for all the trouble I've caused. I really want to thank you. Thank you. Thank you for being so patient. Thank you."

The misery that followed is still so inchoate to me that I can't fully describe it. I cried every night of that March, that April, that May, maybe that June, of 1989. David and Gabriel would already have fallen asleep and the Mickey Mouse song tape that Gabriel insisted on listening to night after night would be playing in my ear, and I would be crying and crying in the dark. I had no idea why I was crying. I was supposed to be happy. I had a job, a job at a "good" university. "What sa matta? *¿De qué te quejas? ¿Dime, qué te falta?*" The tears would start and there was no stopping them. After a while, they were like old friends. "Hello, heartache, sit down."

I was now lost in a different wilderness, the wilderness of success in the university system, success I myself had striven for. After being the woman who couldn't translate herself, I had suddenly become the woman who translated herself too well. And in the midst of it all, I was planning to turn the tales of a Mexican street peddler into a book that would be read within the very same academy that had toyed with my most intimate sense of identity and then, with even less compunction, bought me out. Fresh from the horror of being a translated woman, I would now turn around and translate another woman for consumption on this side of the border.

For, you see, once I took the job at Michigan, I was immediately tabulated into the list of new minority hirings. Whenever there is a minority faculty event, I'm invited. At women's studies gatherings I am sometimes introduced as a woman of color. There are still so few

minority faculty on campus that even a gringa Latina, an impure Cubanita like me, counts for something.

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Will I lose my job for saying all this? The Cubanita inside me, impure though she may be, is still afraid to speak up. Will her letters be torn up? Will they take the fellowship away? Be grateful, be grateful, say thank you. Sorry, Michigan. You're not angry with me?

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Telling this story of how I came to my place of privilege in academics, I feel as though I have put out a search warrant for that woman who thought it worthwhile to sit listening year after year to another woman's story in the kitchen of a little cement house in a Mexican town. I have a clearer picture now of this woman who has been hiding behind the story of another woman's life. I recognize her. I understand that part of her interest in creating this text of a Mexican woman's life story has to do with her own painful, and unresolved, confrontation with the great books, as well as with her father's mutilation of her writing; and that her desire to recognize Esperanza as a writer whose words are written in the sand of storytelling and conversation has to do with her own lack of language, "the language to clarify [her] resistance to the literate" as well as her adulation of the literate.[11] The biography in the shadow of the biography.

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In September of 1990, when I was in Mexquitic again, I had a few minutes to myself and was trying to sit down and read a book (what else?) when I heard a knock at the door. I swung open the narrow wooden door not knowing who to expect at that late morning hour and saw an elderly man standing there expectantly. Children's clothes hung from his outstretched arms as though they were two rails specially made for the purpose. Ah, a peddler, I thought. *"¿Gusta ver el surtido que traigo de ropa de niños?"* he said to me, politely zestful. I thought to myself, Well, I could be nice and look at what he has to offer and maybe buy something if it's not too expensive, but that's going to take time and I haven't been able to read a single book since I got to Mexquitic. *"No, ahorita no, gracias,"* I said, and closed the door.

And then, when I went inside, I began to think I had done something terrible, something terribly self-denying. Both my Russian and Turkish grandfathers were peddlers in Cuba; my maternal grandfather eventually came to own a little lace store, but my paternal grandfather, *el turco*, remained a peddler. It's only recently that my father has begun to talk openly about how Abuelo went from door to door selling blankets that he carried on his back and men's suits that he draped on his arms. For my father, who was dragged along on peddling trips to the outskirts of Havana, this truth about his past and his origins has been a source of shame, long hidden, and he spoke with irony about how his father wanted him to learn the "family business." Now my father is the Latin American sales representative for a large textile firm in New York, but in moments of self-deprecating humor he has called himself a peddler of *basura*, of junk; it is his job to sell the fabric no one wants to buy on this side of the border to clients in Panama, in the Dominican Republic, and, yes, in Mexico. He's a translated man himself.

Because of my father's shame, it didn't occur to me at first that my work with Esperanza, the Mexican street peddler, was also a bridge to my own past and the journey my family has made to shift their class identity. How many cultural and class borders I, too, have crossed to end up in the position of being able to turn away the peddler that came to my door, while in all good conscience devoting years to writing up hundreds of pages of another peddler's life story.

I may cringe when I am at a party hosted by a colleague deeply committed to working-class and postcolonial struggles who just happens to have Persian rugs with just the right patina in every room of the house, but I also know that it is for life in this world and this social class that I have been preparing myself since finishing graduate school. During the years I lived in Mexico after my doctorate, without any definite sense of my final destination, didn't I start to collect hand-knotted linens, an inlaid wood hope chest, bark paintings, ceramic tiles, lacquered trays from Olinalá? I didn't have a home yet of my own—I wasn't sure where home would be—but one day I dreamed of a house filled with the things I had brought back from my travels, and maybe even a Persian rug or two.

"Tell me more about what Abuelo sold in Cuba," I ask my father. And he tells me that for a long time my grandfather sold blankets from the United States, because blankets that said "Made in U.S.A." were

highly valued. And, he adds, with a sudden flash of memory, the brand name of the blankets was Beacon. Who could have known that two generations later, across another border, his granddaughter in the United States would compose a book about a peddler, and that this book would be borne into print by a publishing house bearing the same name as the blankets her grandfather once sold on the streets of Havana?

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I have mixed feelings about everything.
Soy un ajiaco de contradicciones.
Vexed, hexed, complexed,
hyphenated, oxygenated, illegally alienated . . .

***—Gustavo Pérez Firmat, "Bilingual Blues," from* Carolina Cuban**

With all the discussion of ethnographic writing going on at the moment, so little is said about how each of us comes to the pen and the computer and the authority to speak and author texts. When Clifford Geertz writes about "the burden of authorship" or James Clifford writes about "ethnographic authority," they don't say authorship is a privilege to which many of us are not born, but arrive at, often clumsily, often painfully, often through a process of self-betrayal and denial; they don't say that authorship is a privilege constituted by the gender, sociohistorical background, and class origins, or lately, class diasporas, of the anthropologist doing the writing.[12]

As anthropologists we often deny, or leave behind in our closets, our class-embeddedness and travel far away to work with peasants, construction workers, miners, hunter-gatherers, peddlers, and factory workers. But when we come home, we tend to live out our lives in "good" middle-class neighborhoods where we rarely encounter the working people we become so close to in the course of doing our projects. Those whose nationality, racial, ethnic, or class position make them uneasy insiders in the academic world often feel as if they are donning and removing masks in trying to form a bridge between the homes they have left and the new locations of privileged class identity they now occupy.[13] How far can one go in shuttling back and forth

across these borders without losing everything in the translation? José Piedra, a Cuban-American literary critic, says that a friend characterizes him as someone who describes Spanish America to the gringos, "of whom you are almost one." As Piedra notes, gringos have a long history of crossing into Spanish America, "to seduce and borrow our land, people, and texts," and now, ironically, some of us on this side of the border are "moving into their homes and academic settings, as if we were ourselves pretending to be second-rate *gringos*."[14]

For a long time I tried to be a second-rate gringa. Having been put through a personal crisis of representation, I now claim the right to speak from somewhere else, as another new mestiza who has infiltrated the academy.[15] If I'm going to be counted as a minority, if I'm going to be on the margin, then I'm going to claim that space and speak from it, but in the interests of a politics that challenges the language of authenticity and racial purity. I will no longer apologize and say, "I'm a Latina, but don't worry, I'm not a 'real Latina,' I don't need special privileges," constantly feeling that I haven't passed "the ethnic legitimacy test."[16] I will take my place with other "halfie" ethnographers, who know what it is like to be placed in situations of being "other," of being the represented rather than the representer, and who therefore are unable "to comfortably assume the self of anthropology . . . the self is split, caught at the intersection of systems of difference."[17] Under these circumstances, you become an ethnographer but refuse to speak from a position of unsituated authority; instead, you try to speak from that very *ajiaco de contradicciones* that makes you a halfie, a mestiza, a Norte Mexicana, almost a gringa, but not quite. Yet I realize that I will continue to slip in and out of shadow, as I become non-Latina for purposes of inclusion and Latina for purposes of exclusion, just the way my comadre is visibly Indian and yet invisibly Indian in Mexican society.[18] And the dilemma will remain: the mestiza still speaks, in large part, to the gringos and gringas, whose homes and academic settings she has moved into. She is illegally alienated. Translator, traitor.

"We grow up repudiating the local and the personal in favor of what will get us ahead and away," writes Mary John in a suggestive essay about her own place in the Western academy as a feminist student from India who has come to the United States in pursuit of a "good" education. Noting how the increasingly ritualistic litany of naming

one's race, class, and gender intersection has become unsatisfying, she calls for a more profound questioning of how identities are shaped in the process of attaining a university education. "Education is more obviously a process," she writes, "by which we learn to avow and remember certain knowledges and devalue and forget others." What we cannot tell ourselves we know, what we have to repress of ourselves in the process of becoming educated, become the "sanctioned ignorances" of our knowledge.[19] It is the sanctioned ignorances of my own ethnographic authority that I have tried to interrogate here.

We all bring different burdens of memory, different sanctioned ignorances, to the task of writing ethnography, to be sure. And there is a special burden that authorship carries if you have ever occupied a borderland place in the dominant culture, especially if you were told at some point in your life that you didn't have what it takes to be an authority on, an author of, anything. It means writing without entitlement, without permission. It means writing as a "literary wetback," as the Chicana poet Alicia Gaspar de Alba puts it, without "the 'right' credentials . . . to get across."[20]

It is not just Esperanza, then, who is a literary wetback. Even though I have borne her story across to this side of the border, I recognize that I, too, in a quite different way, am a literary wetback in the world of academic letters, a wetback despite the papers that tell me I'm okay, I'm in, I'm a legal alien.

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Now that I am on the other side, I must confront the challenge of playing the role of *la profesora* in ways that go against the grain of education's power to not let students know what they know. But I tend to be *demasiado* nice and have felt like an intellectual maid when students come to me for help cleaning up their proposals and papers before they show them to their more aloof and intimidating professors.

During the summer of 1991, as I struggled to finish this book, I let myself be interrupted by the visit of a young woman who came with her parents and sister to tell me that she had decided against attending graduate school at Michigan. She had expressed her desire to be at Michigan under any condition, and so I had taken time to work at obtaining a teaching assistantship for her. But as the summer drew to a close, she began to have second thoughts, and when it turned out she

could still go to another top university with a full fellowship, she decided to back out. Her mother intensified the pressure by saying that she didn't understand why you would want to have to work to study when you could go to a university where they would pay you to study. But this student, who had heard me speak at a conference and begun to view me as a role model, wanted very much to work with me. Herself the daughter of a father who is a professor, she had called me at home several times to let me know of her interest and her indecision. I had given her as much time as she seemed to need, identifying fully with her predicament. The woman professor, the impure Cubanita come up from the bottom, feels she has to give of herself; she's still paying her debt, still showing her gratitude.

August 5, 1991. It is late morning, the day after Gabriel's birthday party, and my hair is still slightly wet. I've quickly pulled it up under a thick braided headband. The student and her family sit with me in the living room. I try to act the professor, steady, calm, offering kind words of sympathy, but as the confident, youthful-looking mother with the tennis figure looks me over, I imagine her thinking: for this husky Latina woman come up from peddlers, this woman who works on life histories and god knows what other marginal things, my precious daughter is going to give up a fellowship at a good university where grey-haired men in grey suits will give her a good education? I'm conscious of the tomato-red band squeezing my temples, the ringlets wet on my neck, and as the mother continues to watch me, I start to feel like Carmen Miranda, tropical fruit ripening, rotting, on my head. I start to think I can imagine how Esperanza must have felt when I kept pointing my camera at her as she walked down the streets of San Luis Potosí with the bucket of produce on her head.

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When I left Mexquitic in 1990 at the end of October, I felt sad that I would have to miss the Day of the Dead that year. And then, just after I returned to Ann Arbor, I heard that Sandra Cisneros and her students were going to put up an altar in the main office of the American Culture Program. When I saw the altar, with the candles lit, the offerings of sweet pan de muertos, and all the santitos, I felt such joy. Here, in the humdrum florescent space where learning is supposed to take place, there was grace, beauty, light; there was the "living border," a

new world of possibilities made "out of the experience of displacement," a closing of the gap between "our America" and "the other America, which is not ours."[21] At the center of her altar, Sandra had hung up Ester Hernández's *La Ofrenda*, a silk screen print of a short-haired Chicana in profile, with the image of the Virgin of Guadalupe radiating from her naked back.

I came full circle—or better, the circle widened, stretched, opened, for me that day. I met Sandra Cisneros for the first time on the Day of the Dead, the same day I met my comadre Esperanza Hernández. On that day, in a class discussion in which I took part, Sandra Cisneros spoke of the newfound delight that she and other Chicanas have discovered in the spiritual practices of Mexican women. Chicanas like herself, who have made it into the academy or the literary world, are reclaiming these practices, she said, because their families were often afraid that claiming them reduced you to being a backward Mexican. Now they light candles for each other before a decision on tenure or the publication of a new essay, poem, or book. And every year, for the muertitos, they make their altares.[22] On this side of the border, it has now become possible for Sandra Cisneros to say, "*Nos estamos haciendo muy brujitas*" (We're becoming very witchy), and laugh.

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July–August 1993. By December of 1992 I had the book. I held it in my hands. Smiled along with the picture of my comadre and I giggling on the back cover. Opened the book. Closed it. Taught it. Peddled it. And all the time I was wondering: what will my comadre think when she sees the book? Finally, I placed it in her hands. She kept it for a few days. Showed it to her customers in San Luis. Listened as I read passages to her from it. Then she gave the book back to me. "I already know my historia, *" she said. "And besides, this is in English. My children can't read it." I insisted she keep the book as a souvenir. "No, comadre, you take it back. Sell it. So it won't be sitting there." If I returned next time with the book in Spanish, would she accept it then? Yes, she would. . . . It pained me to pack the book away again. But I understood that not accepting* Translated Woman *was my comadre's way of refusing to say goodbye, of refusing to be translated, of refusing to end this book.*

Notes

Chronology